



Figure 5: One client in master area, four in stack area, with highly skewed area ratio

to launch applications. What you do have is a narrow bar running along the top edge of the screen, displaying some numbers and symbols, with 'dwm-5.9' in the right corner. This bar is known as... or shall we just call it 'bar' for now. Try pressing `Alt+B` to toggle the bar visibility. The numbers you see are virtual desktops (called tags in dwm)—dwm provides nine of them by default. Try `Alt+[Num]` to switch between tags. The weird '`[]`' symbol you see next to the tags is your current tiling layout. dwm offers three layouts by default—tile (`[]`), monocle (`[M]`) and float (`<>`). The '`dwm-5.9`' string you see in the far left can actually be changed to show useful information like the current date, time, network status, battery status, etc.

This is a good time to get acquainted with dwm's keyboard short-cuts. Remember, keyboard short-cuts are of prime importance in tiling WMs, and you should know them as if your life depended on it. You can configure them to your liking, but it helps to get acquainted with a few default ones.

<code>Alt+Shift+Enter</code>	Launch xterm
<code>Alt+Shift+C</code>	Kill a client (a window, if you must insist)
<code>Alt+t</code>	Switch to tile layout
<code>Alt+m</code>	Switch to monocle layout
<code>Alt+f</code>	Switch to floating layout
<code>Alt+b</code>	Show/hide bar
<code>Alt+p</code>	Launch dmenu
<code>Alt+[num]</code>	Switch to tag [num]
<code>Alt+Shift+Q</code>	Quit dwm

Dmenu is an application launcher from the author of dwm, following the same minimalist philosophy as dwm. It is a part of the *suckless-tools* package we installed earlier.

Now we will try out the tiling modes of dwm. First, close any open clients (`Alt+Shift+C`) and switch to tile mode (`Alt+t`). Now open xterm using `dmenu`; press `Alt+p` and you should see the bar replaced with something like Figure 2. Start typing the name of the app you wish to launch, and once dmenu has narrowed down the search, select it using the arrow keys, and press 'Enter'. Launch xterm this way. It will occupy the entire screen. (See Figure 3—the number '1' has been added by me.) Open another xterm client (using either `dmenu` or `Alt+Shift+Enter`). You will find that the previously opened xterm automatically resizes and moves to make space for this newly opened one.

In Figure 4, Area 1 is called the master area and Area 2 is called the stack area. The master area can hold a single client, while the stack area holds all the remaining ones. Any newly opened client always occupies the master area, and existing clients get pushed into the stack area. Open up a couple of more xterms to see how this works. You can switch focus between clients using `Alt+j` and `Alt+k`. Focused clients are denoted by a blue border, while the rest have a grey border. You can move a focused client from the stack area to the master area using `Alt+Enter`. Play around with these short-cuts till you get the hang of exactly how the tiling works. Finally, you can change the ratio between the master and stacking areas using `Alt+h` and `Alt+i` (Figure 5).

Now switch to the monocle layout (`Alt+m`) to have the focused client occupy the entire screen. Note how the '`[]`' sign in the bar changes when you switch layouts. This layout is equivalent to maximised windows in floating WMs. Note that the `Alt+j`, `Alt+k` and `Alt+Enter` short-cuts will work in this layout too.

The final layout is the floating kind, which is equivalent to your conventional floating WMs. Move the clients around using `Alt+LMB+Drag` and resize them using `Alt+RMB+Drag`. Note that you can switch individual clients into floating mode, without affecting the layout of the rest, by using `Alt+Shift+Space`. Floating clients always stay above the tiled ones.

Tags in dwm are a more powerful version of virtual desktops in KDE/GNOME, etc. A client can have more than one tag associated with it, and you can view all clients from any number of tags simultaneously. Use `Alt+[num]` to view all clients with the tag [num] and `Alt+Ctrl+[num]` to view clients with tag [num] in addition to currently visible clients. Use `Alt+Shift+[num]` to associate the focused client with tag [num], and `Alt+Ctrl+Shift+[num]` to associate in addition to current tag associations.

There is still a lot more tweaking left to do before you can use dwm as a full-fledged replacement for Unity. This includes configuring a system tray so you can use the NetworkManager applet under dwm, displaying some meaningful information in the bar instead of the curt 'dwm-5.9'. It also includes configuring dwm by editing its source code (have a look at `/usr/local/src/dwm-5.9/config.h` to get started), and making your GNOME themes and settings carry over to your dwm session (if you open any GNOME apps at this point, they will have an ugly theme and unreadable fonts).



Note: Use '`nautilus--no-desktop`' in dmenu to launch Nautilus, or else it will mess up your dwm session. A default rule in dwm specifies that Firefox should open in Tag 9 by default. Happy tiling!



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